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Examiners' Report
Summer 2026

GCSE History 1HI0 P4

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Introduction

On the Period Studies papers all questions are assessed with a focus on particular second-order concepts (AO2): Question 01 on consequence, Question 02 on causation, consequence and change and Question 03 on consequence and significance. The first strand of the mark scheme shows AO2, with the candidate's increasing ability to make generalized comments to more analytical explanations and reasoning focused on the relevant second-order concept. The second strand of the mark scheme shows how AO1 is assessed with the candidate's ability to progress from responses with limited knowledge and understanding of the topic to deploying accurate and relevant information to show good knowledge and understanding of the period. Centres are reminded that the indicative content in the mark scheme does not state what must be in responses but is meant to exemplify the range of material which examiners might expect to see in candidates' work. As the mark scheme guidance states any other relevant material must be credited. As mentioned in previous Principal Examiner reports, there are responses that write in the first person, such as a diary or letter, for Question 02. Such responses should be avoided, as although AO1 can sometimes be rewarded, it is very unlikely that there will be any aspects of the work which can access AO2.

Question 1

For Question 01(a) at Level 2 most responses explained the rising tensions between the superpowers as a consequence of the Potsdam Conference which was supported with specific information such as disagreements over reparations, Stalin's reluctance to hold free elections in Poland and the increasing fears and distrust following the USA's successful testing of the atomic bomb. There were also responses which commented on the Allies' commitment to denazification. Level 1 responses tended to be basic comments with assertions such as 'tensions rose' without any support. There were some unrewardable consequences which were too long-term to be seen as a direct consequence of the Potsdam Conference (such as the formation of NATO). A misconception seen in several responses was that the USA had used the atomic bomb on Japan before the actual conference.

For Question (01) (b) at Level 2 most talked of the social consequences of families and friends divided and supported this with specific information about the Wall's duration for nearly 30 years, the number estimated to have been shot attempting to cross from East Berlin, the ending of the 'brain drain' and the occasional mention of Peter Fechter. Over Level 2 response talked about more political consequences such as the propaganda opportunities it created for the West portraying the East as having to 'imprison' its own people or the West's commitment to West Berlin with Kennedy's 'ich bin ein Berliner' speech. A significant number of responses were awarded Level 2 by explaining how the construction of the Wall in some ways reduced tension with the GDR now having a guaranteed labour supply, the two Germanies now having to learn to accommodate each other and Kennedy's statement regarding the wall being better than a war. Level 1 responses tended to be simple generalised comments without specific support such as 'people were shot' or 'families were split up.' There were some unrewardable responses which focused on causation rather than consequences, confused the Wall with the Berlin Blockade or gave a description of the actual Wall itself.

1 (a) Explain **one** consequence of the Potsdam Conference (July–August 1945).

(4)

One consequence of the potsdam conference is that krouschev was leading the conference and then he got rid of nixo. while in the potsdam conference in July 1945. this then caused tension towards the leaders of the USSR.

(b) Explain **one** consequence of the construction of the Berlin Wall (1961).

(4)

One consequence of the construction of the berlin wall is that it was created to split the Berlin in half and leave peoples families where they cant go over to the other side. while some people tried to get over the Berlin wall they couldn't because they would be shot or got taken.

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Examiner Comments

1a) There is no rewardable material as the tension comment follows incorrect material.
1b) Fulfils the requirements of features of period for AO2 with 'split Berlin in half.' This explanation is supported with good knowledge (A01) 'families can't go over the other side' and they would be 'shot'. The overall mark is therefore low Level 3.

1 (a) Explain **one** consequence of the Potsdam Conference (July–August 1945).

(4)

one consequence of the potsdam conference was that tensions grew stronger between the soviet union and the usa as the two superpowers, started not agreeing with each other. The secona koria war nad just concuieaea ana the allies were deciaing what to ao with germany.

(b) Explain **one** consequence of the construction of the Berlin Wall (1961).

(4)

one consequence of the construction of the Berlin Wall in 1961 was that it split the east ana west causing major development set backs in the east, whereas the west were thriving. The Berlin wall also caused families to be scrperatea for over 20 years allowing the soviet union to nave control.

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Examiner Comments

1a) Fulfils the requirements for AO2 at Level 2 by features of the period – 'tensions grow stronger', 'started not agreeing with each other'. This explanation is supported with good knowledge (AO1)' the second world war had just concluded' and 'the allies were deciding what to do with Germany.' The response is therefore 4 marks as both strands of L2 mark scheme have been met.
1b) Fulfils the requirements for AO2 at Level 2 by features of a period shown with 'split the east and west'. AO1 is shown with good knowledge 'caused families to be separated for over 20 years', 'west was thriving' and 'allowing the soviet union to have control'. The response is therefore 4 marks as both strands of L2 mark scheme have been met.

Question 2

Question 02 focuses on an analytical narrative and the AO2 concepts of causation, consequence and change. The question includes two stimulus points and focuses on a specific period when key events, developments and ideas can be analysed as a sequence of events leading to an outcome (AO2). The narrative offered does not necessarily need to cover the entire period stated in the question but any material outside of the stipulated time frame in the question is unrewardable. To be awarded Level 3 for AO1 (information, knowledge and understanding) candidates must address three more aspects of content. Although most candidates do use the two stimulus points for aspects of content, they do not necessarily have to use those provided.

At Level 3 candidates demonstrated a clear analytical narrative showing how one event linked to the next and supported their analysis with good knowledge and understanding. Many responses at this level began their narrative with the Cuba developing closer relations with the USSR and consequent US concerns followed by the Bay of Pigs, the spy plane taking photographs of nuclear missile sites, the October crisis and de-escalation.

Level 2 responses tended to be analytical accounts that only covered two aspects of content (normally those given by the two stimulus points) or were descriptive accounts with limited linkage between events. There were also responses which included unrewardable material outside of the time frame in the question by writing about events prior to 1961 and detailing the events of the Cuban Revolution or events after 1962 such as the 'hotline', the treaties signed from 1963 onwards or the coming of détente. Level 1 responses almost invariably simply added a piece of information to one or both stimulus points provided.

2 Write a narrative account analysing the key events of the Cold War crisis over Cuba in the years 1961–62.

(8)

You **may** use the following in your answer:

- the Bay of Pigs (1961)
- Soviet nuclear missile sites in Cuba

You **must** also use information of your own.

Following growing relations between the USSR and Cuba (with Cuba only being 90 miles from Florida), John F Kennedy (JFK) launched the bay of pigs invasion in 1961, hoping to overthrow the cuban leader Fidel Castro. JFK trained up 1400 cuban exiles to attack Cuba. However, these 1400 were easily defeated by 20,000 cubans with rallying support for Castro. As a result of the ~~JFK Confirmed~~ failure, JFK continued attempts to sabotage Castro, for example via 'operation mongoose'. Although JFK tried to keep US involvement a secret in the invasion, the planes used were easily recognisable as american. Therefore this was humiliating for the US, who were seen as hypocritical for condemning the USSRs invasion of Hungary (1956) then invaded Cuba. This led ~~the~~ Cuba to get even closer to the USSR, who began training armies and supplying weapons such as SAMs. As a result, by the end of 1961 Castro declared himself a Communist, angering JFK.

The USSR's supplying of missiles led to the Cuban missile crisis. On the 14th of October, a US U2 spy plane captured images of a missile site in Cuba, close enough to launch a devastating attack on the USA. Another plane spotted 20 soviet ships in the atlantic heading to Cuba - likely with nuclear weapons. As a result, on the 16th the USA imposed a naval blockade declaring they were prepared to sink soviet ships and use war. For response, JFK also demanded the missile site to be dismantled. In response, the USSR agreed to remove them if the USA promised not to invade Cuba again. Khrushchev then added he also wanted the US missile sites in Turkey removed. This agreement led to the soviet ships turning around and the cuban missile sites removal. In response the US also so discreetly removed their sites in Turkey, despite Truman ignored how a US pilot had been shot down and vowed for the sake of avoiding a war and getting missiles removed.

As a result of this crisis, it led to better attempts of co-operation between the superpowers as both sides feared getting that close to a nuclear war again. Therefore it decreased reduced superpower tensions.

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Examiner Comments

The response is high Level 3. There is a clear sequence of events leading to an outcome, with clear examples of linkage of events and analysis (AO2) and this is supported with accurate and relevant information showing good knowledge and understanding with more than three aspects of content (AO1).

2 Write a narrative account analysing the key events of the Cold War crisis over Cuba in the years 1961–62.

(8)

You **may** use the following in your answer:

- the Bay of Pigs (1961)
- Soviet nuclear missile sites in Cuba

You **must** also use information of your own.

*

The Bay OF Pigs in 1961 was ordered by Kennedy to try and assasinate castro. This was because Cuban refugees fled to the US after castros uprising as they feared communism. Kennedy and the CIA were planing to send the refugees back, but armed. However they were met by castro and they were all killed. This humiliated Kennedy as the CIA are supposed to be the best intelligence agency in the world.

The USA and Cuban leaders were now on bad terms because of their communism views. The USSR then found out that Cuba was now a communist state

and also didnt like the US. So the USSR planted soviet missile silos in Cuba. This made tensions worse for both the usa and cuba, and the USA and soviets. This led to the USA planting ~~a~~ missile silos in Turkey to react to the threat by the USSR.

* The uprising of castro was because he was the leader of a rebellion against the existing Cuban government. He did not like the USA and he was a violent leader to his people. This caused many ~~not~~ cuban refugees to go to the USA.

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Examiner Comments

A narrative given showing some organisation of material into a sequence of events (AO2) at Level 2. There is some knowledge and understanding (AO1) but this only covers two aspects of content (the Bay of Pigs and Soviet missile sites) as the last paragraph is outside of the time frame in the question. The response is therefore awarded high Level 2.

Question 3

For the first Question 03 choice on the Berlin Blockade, level 3 responses gave an analytical explanation of how the Berlin Blockade had a direct impact on the souring of East-West relations with the consequent Berlin Airlift and how this led to humiliation for Stalin and its presentation as a victory for the West and its confirmation for the USA's commitment to western Europe. These responses included good knowledge and understanding with accurate and relevant information on the impact of the Berlin Airlift on West Berliners, often described Operation Vittles followed by the division of Germany and the city of Berlin itself and the formation of NATO. At Level 2 responses often gave more implied comments on the impact of the Blockade on East-West relations but were mainly narrative or descriptive accounts of the Blockade and Berlin Airlift. Level 1 responses often gave a very limited and generalised comment such as 'people could not get food' or 'leaders were angry.' There were also some responses with unrewardable material as candidates had confused the Blockade as a cause or consequence of the building of the Berlin Wall.

For the second Question 03 choice on Czechoslovakia in 1968, Level 3 responses gave an analytical explanation as to how the events had an impact on East-West relations with the USA's condemnation of Soviet actions but an unwillingness to strain superpower relations too far. Response at this level for AO1 generally commented on the nature of the attempted reforms and the concept of 'socialism with a human face', the military response from Moscow (many also commentated on the use of forces from other Eastern bloc states), the overshadowing of events in eastern Europe in the USA by the Vietnam War and the USSR's introduction of the Brezhnev Doctrine to assert its control over the satellite states. Some responses included the negative reaction to Soviet actions from the communist movement in western Europe. Responses at Level 2 were invariably a narrative or descriptive events of the Prague Spring and many at this level often showed some confusion with events in Hungary by citing Czechoslovakia's desire to leave the Warsaw Pact. At Level 1 responses were generally a basic comment such as 'they tried to bring changes' or 'many were killed by the Soviet army.'

For the third Question 03 choice on Reagan's actions, Level 3 responses gave an analytical explanation that argued he increased tensions between the superpowers, that he actually decreased tensions or offered both explanations. At this Level most responses included supporting knowledge and information for AO1 on his increased spending on arms, the SDI ('Star Wars') programme, his 'evil empire' speech, the concept of the 'Second Cold War', the meetings with Gorbachev and the INF Treaty. Occasionally candidates offered the 'tear down this wall' speech as part of their response. Higher Level 2 responses tended to be mainly narrative or descriptive accounts with an attempted analysis on linking the material to its impact for superpower relations. A significant number of low or mid Level 2 responses included some unrewardable material with the misunderstanding that Reagan was responsible for the coming of less tense relations between the superpowers in the 1970s and the bringing about of SALT 1. Some responses also remained in Level 2 by drifting primarily into explaining Gorbachev's actions rather than Reagan's. Level 1 responses tended to be simple comments or assertions on 'Star Wars' such as 'it was very expensive' or 'Reagan made up how good it was' without linking the generalised information given to superpower relations.

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

- ☒ The importance of the Berlin blockade (1948–49) for tension between East and West.
- ☒ The importance of events in Czechoslovakia in 1968 for relations between East and West.
- ☒ The importance of US President Reagan's actions for superpower relations in the 1980s.

The Berlin blockade was incredibly significant for increasing ~~the~~ tensions between the super-powers. One reason for this is its ~~pe~~ perception by and response from the West. The U.S saw this action as a further "~~Stalinist~~ attempt to expand the ~~pow~~ power and borders of the USSR. To them, this confirmed their assumption that Stalinism was an expansionist and aggressive ideology and could be used as evidence of the incompatibility of Communism ~~and~~ and Liberty and self determination. By closing all roads, rail-tracks and canals into Berlin, the Soviets appeared to be resulting to Medieval siege tactics. In response to this act of aggression and expansion, the USA used large planes, including second world war bombers, to land an average of ~~1,000~~ 1,000 tons of supplies into Berlin per day. This reached its peak in January 1949 where 170,000

tons of supplies were flown into the city. This, and the subsequent fall of the blockade, signalled a Western ideological victory. This display of financial strength, as the airlift was an expensive endeavor, showed the success of Capitalism over Communism, angering the USSR.

A final way this increased tensions was through the following creation of NATO. This "North Atlantic Treaty Organisation" promised mutual defence against any threat, though it was created to oppose the USSR, through Article 5 of its constitution. The Soviet leadership perceived this as the US expanding its military empire towards their territory. This was partially proven right by the creation of US bases in the UK; such as Milderhall, and bases in West Germany, adjacent to Soviet territory.

- ☒ The importance of the Berlin blockade (1948–49) for tension between East and West.
- ☒ The importance of events in Czechoslovakia in 1968 for relations between East and West.
- ☒ The importance of US President Reagan's actions for superpower relations in the 1980s.

The Czechoslovak revolution of 1968 led to an increase of tensions. The overthrowal of the government under Dubček showed a desire among citizens of the Eastern Bloc for more Western principals of Democracy and a resentment of some mechanisms of the Soviet state, such as secret policing and control of media. The Soviet response to this revolution had two key effects on relations, both resulting in a souring. One is that it outlined the USSR's resolution in maintaining control and opposition to democracy and true freedom. By using their right to intervene as outlined in the Warsaw Pact, the Soviets showed an autocratic control. Furthermore, this response outlined them as tyrannical. By using the Red Army and thousands of tanks to crush civilian protests, the USSR presented themselves as anti-civil liberties and as violators of human

rights. This improved the U.S's position on the Global stage and increased tensions between the two states as the west was shocked by the cruelty of the USSR.

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Examiner Comments

In the first response there is an explanation showing analysis of importance for tension between East and West with confirmed assumptions, improved US position, and increased tensions for AO2 at Level 3. There is accurate and relevant information showing good knowledge and understanding, eg Stalinism being expansionist, details on blockade, gives AO1 at Level 3. The response is therefore high Level 3.
The second response shows as an analysis of importance with explanation, eg resentment of mechanisms of the Soviet state and its effects on the souring relations, for AO2 at Level 3. For AO1 there is good knowledge and understanding with accurate and relevant information for Level 3. The response is therefore high Level 3.

☒ The importance of the Berlin blockade (1948–49) for tension between East and West.

☒ The importance of events in Czechoslovakia in 1968 for relations between East and West.

☒ The importance of US President Reagan's actions for superpower relations in the 1980s.

One reason as to why the Berlin Blockade was of importance for tension between the East and West, was because of the fact that the Berlin Blockade caused extreme ~~the~~ hunger and a shortage of nessesities such as food, clothes, coal etc.... Due to the Berlin Blockade all railway tracks were closed off and the ~~the~~ US and Britain had to drop resources into East Germany by plane, this humiliated the Soviet Union as ~~there~~ their plan had failed. This lasted for a year until the Soviet Union removed the Blockades ~~ending~~.

Another reason of importance in tension between the East and the West is, it showed how even Soviet occupated land could be reached by forces from the west.

- ☒ The importance of the Berlin blockade (1948–49) for tension between East and West.
- ☒ The importance of events in Czechoslovakia in 1968 for relations between East and West.
- ☒ The importance of US President Reagan's actions for superpower relations in the 1980s.

The events in Czechoslovakia were of importance to relations between the East and the West, as the force used by the Soviet Union against Czechoslovakia showed the brutality within ~~soviet~~ Soviet occupated land.

Another reason as to why the events of Czechoslovakia were important was because it helped the US paint the picture that the USSR was using Controlled force to keep Czechoslovakia under communist rule. This was bad for the USSR as in their eyes they were only trying to remove reforms and capatalist ideologies from Czecoslovakia as under ~~the~~ Dubček there had been reforms to relax ~~Extreme~~ Soviet ~~control~~ Control.

A third reason as to why the events in Czechoslovakia were of importance was due to the fact that of other countries ~~where~~ where Soviet rule might want reforms, which would lead to the collapse of the Soviet Union.

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Examiner Comments

The first response shows an attempt to analyse importance with some reasoning, eg humiliating the Soviet Union in first paragraph for A02 at Level 2. For AO1 the response gives some accurate and relevant information showing some knowledge and understanding. The overall response is therefore mid level 2.
The second response shows an attempt to analyse with a brief focus on relations between East and West (AO2) and some knowledge and understanding is shown (AO1) to give a high Level 2 mark.

Paper Summary

Candidates should be reminded to focus on the date range given in any question, especially on Question 02, as material outside of the time frame is mostly unrewardable, and therefore wastes valuable examination time.

Centres are reminded that candidates need to ensure that to achieve Level 3 on Question 03, they should relate the importance of the named event, individual or development to the situation and/or unfolding development in the second part of the question.

Centres are also reminded that where candidates need extra space for a response, this should be on separate extra paper rather than within the space provided for a different question. Where candidates have special consideration to word process their responses, centres should ensure that their B (British Depth Study) and P (Period Study) responses are separated from each other.

Grade boundaries

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